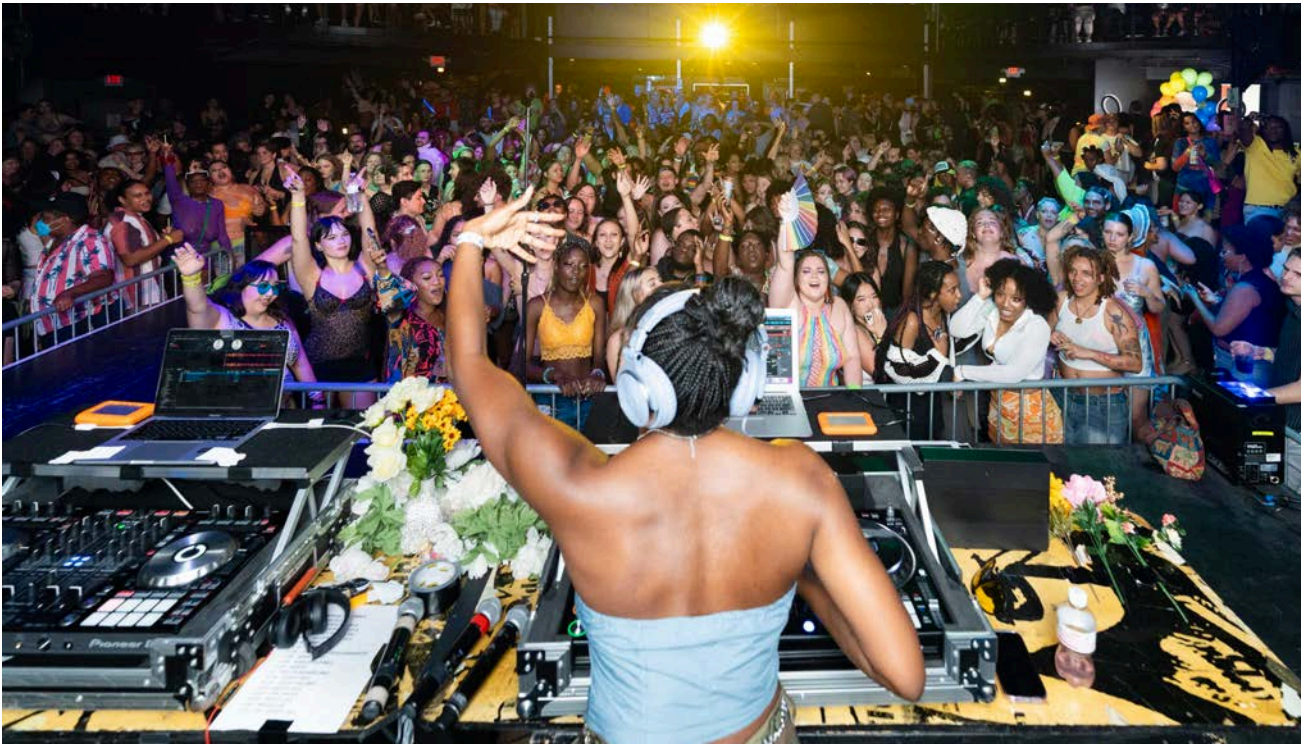


MINNEAPOLIS MUSIC CENSUS



Photos Courtesy of Minneapolis Arts and Cultural Affairs

**SUMMARY REPORT
2024**



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Executive Summary

The 2024 Minneapolis Music Census was a community-led initiative to learn more about the needs of the music ecosystem in our city. The Music Census ran from April 12-May 6, 2024 and received 2,258 responses from people working in the music industry who are 18 years or older and living in the Minneapolis area. The 2024 Minneapolis Music Census was led by the Arts & Cultural Affairs Department is the most extensive music survey of Minneapolis to date.

The Minneapolis music ecosystem is predominantly composed of individuals in the Music Creative sector (75%), with smaller representations in Industry (17%) and Venue/Presenter roles (8%). This composition shows a strong presence of Creatives. We like to see Industry closer to 20%, but this is nearly there. Increasing the Venue/Presenters segment to support Creatives may bring more balance.

Most Creatives (89%) have over 10 years of experience. Key career concerns include stagnant pay rates (39%), rising cost of living (36%), and lack of music work (32%). Local live performances are the primary income source, relied on significantly by 49%. Music Industry occupations are primarily Event/Venue workers, followed by production support and music marketing. Creative annual expenses yields a collective spend of over \$8M annually of which 60% stays local. This 60% retention of local expenses ties with Austin for the highest percentage of Creatives working with local Industry.

Minneapolis Venue/Presenter respondents are live music venues (31%), followed by festivals (15%) and independent promoters (13%), and women lead the gender representation at 51%, compared to 42% for men. On average, venues host 123 live events annually, contributing to a robust live music scene offering 17,653 total events annually. Commercial workspace status indicates a heavy reliance on rented spaces, making them vulnerable to market trends. Venues/Presenters face significant regulatory challenges, with sound policy, cost of permits, and confusion/inefficiency being the most pressing issues. Safety concerns for music ecosystem respondents emphasize the need for safe parking (63%) and nighttime lighting (38%). The Minneapolis 3% Entertainment Tax is generally seen as neutral by 83% of respondents.

Music significantly contributes to the income of Minneapolis music professionals, generating a total of \$62 million annually across all respondents, with 29% of their annual income coming from music and an average annual income from music being \$28,000. Average household income for respondents is \$94K. A significant portion of respondents, 61%, work outside of music, with 85% of these relying on their outside job as their primary source of income.

In terms of developing the music ecosystem, respondents highlight a preference for connections with music services (51%) and affordable rehearsal spaces (47%). Venues/Presenters prioritize a best practice guide for live music (69%) and audience development tools (67%). Only 24% of respondents have received financial assistance for their music work. Financial assistance preferences lean heavily towards financial assistance in the form of funding for tourism and music export (64%) and funding for guaranteed fee for small/medium presentations (58%). For professional development, respondents seek marketing, including social media strategies, and booking/promotion/event production training.

The Minneapolis music ecosystem is generally livable and offers many positive experiences, but has challenges with ageism, elitism, and sexism. The Minneapolis music ecosystem's greatest strengths are that it is safe, non-homophobic, and welcoming.

This report and the online dashboard available at [Minneapolis Arts & Cultural Affairs](#) offer more in-depth data, insights, and opportunities to understand, support, and grow Minneapolis's diverse, dynamic, and energizing music ecosystem and all the benefits it offers culturally and economically.

Introduction

The 2024 Minneapolis Music Census was a community-led initiative to learn more about the needs of the music ecosystem in our city. It aimed to gather important information about the music industry in Minneapolis to help the city and the community make more informed, data-driven decisions and policies. The 2024 Minneapolis Music Census is the most extensive music survey of Minneapolis to date.

The music census launched on April 12, 2024 and ran for three weeks. The study was open to all people working in music in any capacity who are 18 years or older and living in the Minneapolis area, and it was offered in English and Spanish. It was conducted by [Sound Music Cities](#), a Texas based company specializing in music ecosystem research, in partnership with the Arts & Cultural Affairs Department (ACA) and local public and private organizations. Minneapolis joined a multi-city cohort program administered by Sound Music Cities which met monthly to discuss best practices on improving music industries on a city level, allowing Minneapolis to gain insight from other cities conducting similar research.

This summary report has been prepared by Sound Music Cities and includes an overview of the Music Ecosystem Health Assessment based on 10 key indicator areas. The report includes key findings and recommendations. Alongside this report, Sound Music Cities has provided access to an online dashboard where you can find more data at [Minneapolis Arts & Cultural Affairs](#).

INTRODUCTION TO A MUSIC CENSUS

Any strategy to support and grow a music ecosystem begins with a basic understanding of its population. Professional music communities are not easily discoverable using traditional methods (such as through labor statistics or economic data). A music census collects key data points to better understand music people and their economic activity within a specific geography. It provides a baseline for policymakers and the larger community to understand and take action.

The value of a music census goes well beyond the data itself. Such initiatives ignite a range of activities that are conducive to more strategic and sustainable support for local music scenes over the long term, beginning with validating this economically marginalized group, sharing new learning, activating civic and community resources, and ultimately empowering music people to take ownership of change initiatives.

2,258 responses

April 12-May 6, 2024

8% venue/presenter

17% industry

75% music creatives



Photos Courtesy of Minneapolis Arts and Cultural Affairs

A Community Effort

The 2024 study was led by the Minneapolis Arts & Cultural Affairs Department (ACA) and local public and private organizations. This study took a grassroots approach that engaged local partners who hold the relationships with music people. Lead Partners served as the primary means of outreach to music people and these organizations were instrumental in shaping the census itself.

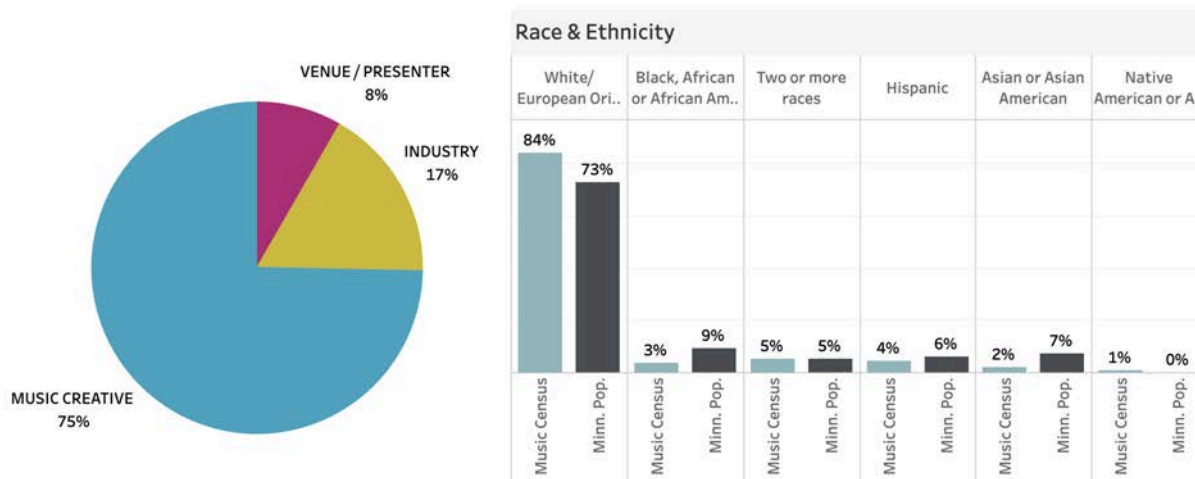
Thank you to our amazing Lead Partners.

American Composers Forum
Arts Midwest
Cedar Cultural Center
Downtown Improvement District
First Avenue
Hennepin Theater Trust
KFAI Radio 90.3
KMOJ Radio 89.9
KRSM Radio 98.9
Liquid Music
Live Nation
MacPhail Center for Music
Meet Minneapolis
Minneapolis Arts Commission
Minneapolis Downtown Council
Minnesota Independent Venue Alliance (MNIVA)
Minnesota Orchestra
Minnesota Public Radio – The Current
MN Citizens for the Arts
Smart North

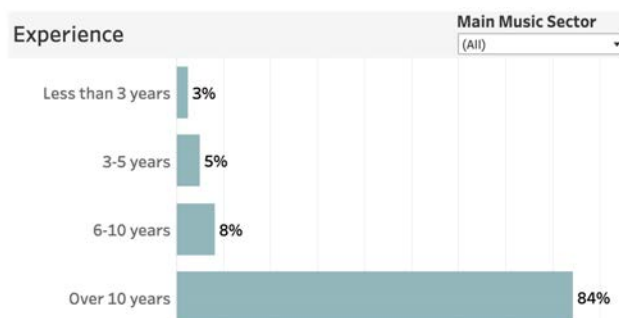
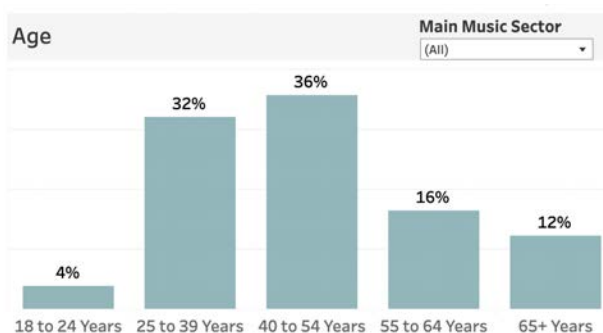
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition

The Minneapolis music ecosystem is predominantly composed of individuals in the Music Creative sector (75%), with smaller representations in Industry (17%) and Venue/Presenter roles (8%). This composition shows a strong presence of Creatives. We like to see Industry closer to 20%, but this is nearly there. Increasing the Venue/Presenters segment to support Creatives may bring more balance.

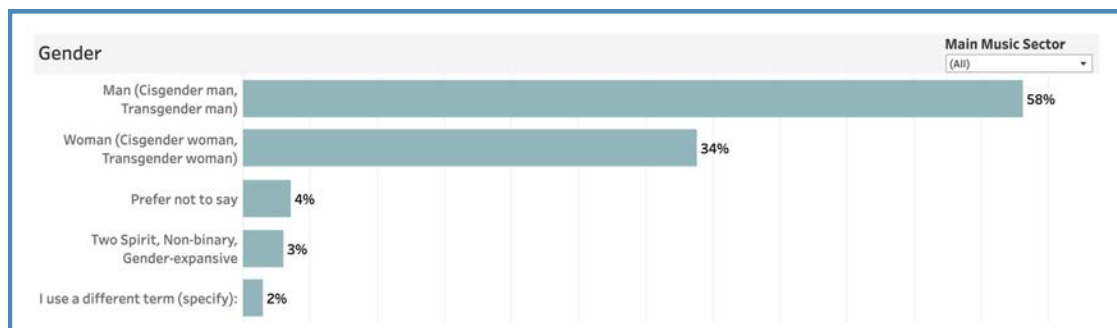


- Race & Ethnicity** - Respondent data reveals a significant majority of White/European Origin individuals, constituting 84% of the Music Census, which is higher compared to the 73% representation in the Minneapolis-St. Paul- Bloomington MSA population. In contrast, Black, African or African American respondents make up 3% of the Music Census, which is lower than their 9% representation in the general population. Similarly, the Asian or Asian American respondents (2%) are lower than the general population (7%). This differences could reflect a difference in the composition of to music ecosystem or a difference in response rates to the Music Census. Other racial and ethnic groups show similar proportions in both the Music Census and the general population.
- Age** - The age distribution shows a diverse range of participants. Those aged 18 to 24 years represent 4% of the population, while 25 to 39 years old make up 32%. The largest age group is 40 to 54 years, accounting for 36%. Participants aged 55 to 64 years constitute 16%, and those 65 years and older represent 12%.
- Experience** - Overall, a significant majority (84%) have over 10 years of experience. This is followed by 8% with 6-10 years of experience, 5% with 3-5 years, and 3% with less than 3 years of experience. The experience level varies by music sector.

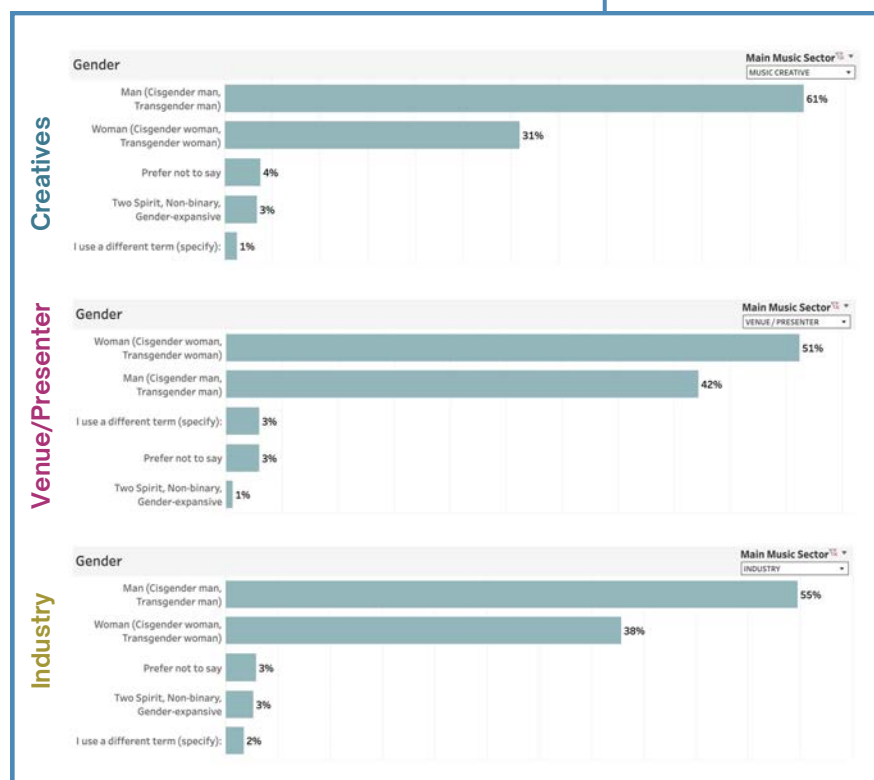


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

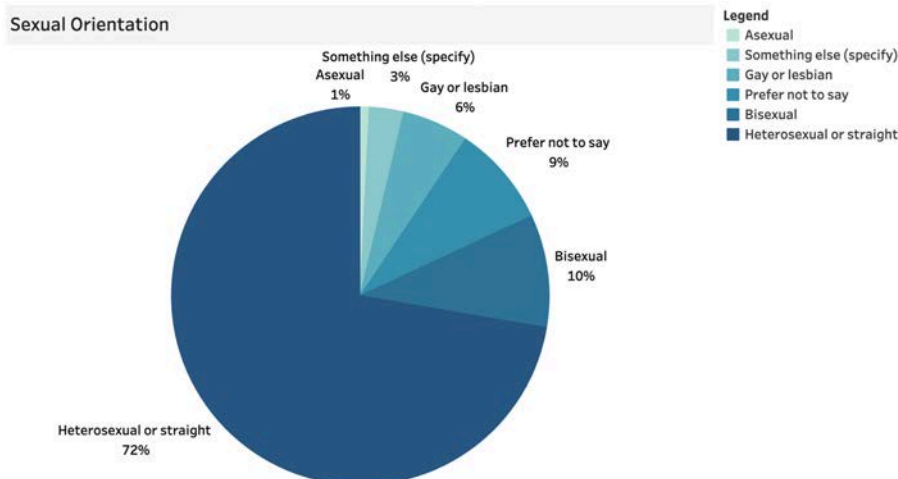
Ecosystem Composition (continued 2/3)



- Gender** - The gender distribution highlights that 58% of participants identify as men (including cisgender and transgender men), while 34% identify as women (including cisgender and transgender women). A small percentage (4%) prefer not to disclose their gender, 3% identify as Two Spirit, Non-binary, or Gender-expansive, and 2% use a different term to describe their gender. In the Creative sector, there is a strong majority of men. The Industry sector also has a higher proportion of men, though the difference between is less pronounced. Conversely, in the Venue/Presenter sector, those who identify as women outnumber all other genders, including men, which is significant since most sectors of music ecosystems are male/men dominant.



- Sexual Orientation** - The Minneapolis music ecosystem displays a diverse range of sexual orientations among its respondents. The majority, 72%, identify as heterosexual or straight. Bisexual individuals make up 10% of the respondents, indicating a notable presence within the community. Those who identify as gay or lesbian represent 6%, Asexual 1%, and 3% identify as something else not specified. Meanwhile, 9% of respondents prefer not to disclose their sexual orientation.



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Composition (continued 3/3)

Plans to Stay in Music and Minneapolis

- **Creatives** - The majority of Creative respondents in the Minneapolis music ecosystem (92%) are confident about continuing to work in music over the next three years, with a strong 77% responding "Definitely Yes." However, there is slightly less certainty about staying in Minneapolis, as 86% responded "Definitely Yes" or "Probably Yes" to living in Minneapolis in three years.
- **Venue/Presenter** - The majority of Venue/Presenter respondents in the Minneapolis music ecosystem (84%) are confident about continuing to work in music over the next three years. Those confident about staying in Minneapolis in three years drops only slightly to 81%. This indicates a strong professional commitment to the music industry and to staying in Minneapolis.
- **Industry** - The majority of Industry respondents in the Minneapolis music ecosystem (85%) are confident about continuing to work in music over the next three years as well as staying in Minneapolis (82%).

“
We have no shortage of talent.
Everywhere you go there is
someone ready to put on a show.
”

“
There are many venues and
free performances that are
funded through grants.
”

“
Still mostly white and
majority is still white men.
”

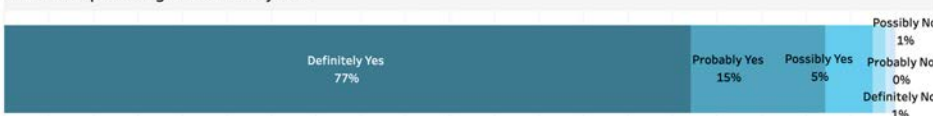
“
Minneapolis has a
great classical choral
music scene. I feel
like even in the way
this survey is worded
it's missing these
numerous choral
musicians in the city.
”

“
I am grateful for
the generosity of
fellow musicians
and my peers in
the local music
scene.
”

“
The white
venues not using
black artists and
when they do it's
for inclusion
events.
”

Creatives

Plan to keep working in Music in 3 years



Plan to keep living in Minneapolis in 3 years



Venue/Presenter

Plan to keep working in Music in 3 years



Plan to keep living in Minneapolis in 3 years



Industry

Plan to keep working in Music in 3 years



Plan to keep living in Minneapolis in 3 years



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile

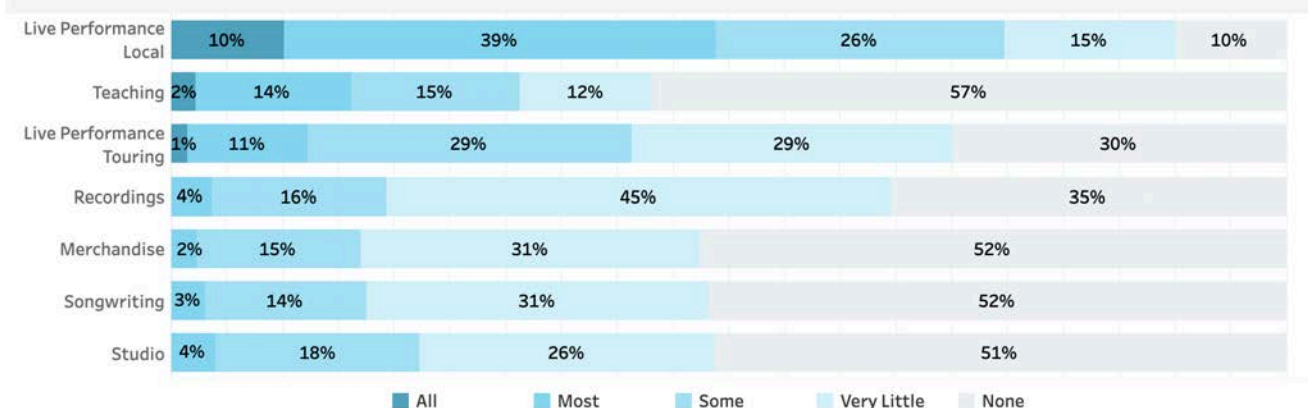
Most Creatives (89%) have over 10 years of experience. Key career concerns include stagnant pay rates (39%), rising cost of living (36%), and lack of music work (32%). Local live performances are the primary income source, relied on significantly by 49%. Average annual expenses total \$4,586, with high costs for rehearsal space, gear rentals, and recording. Creative annual expenses yields a collective spend of over \$8M annually of which 60% stays local. This 60% retention of local expenses ties with Austin for the highest percentage of Creatives working with local Industry.

- Sources of Income** - Income sources for Creatives are varied, with local live performances being the most common, providing income for 10% who rely on it entirely and 39% who use it as a significant source. Teaching is another key income source, followed by touring performances, recordings, merchandise, songwriting, and studio work. However, many creatives report only partial or minimal income from these activities.

“
More nights of live music,
not just Thursday Friday
Saturday.
”

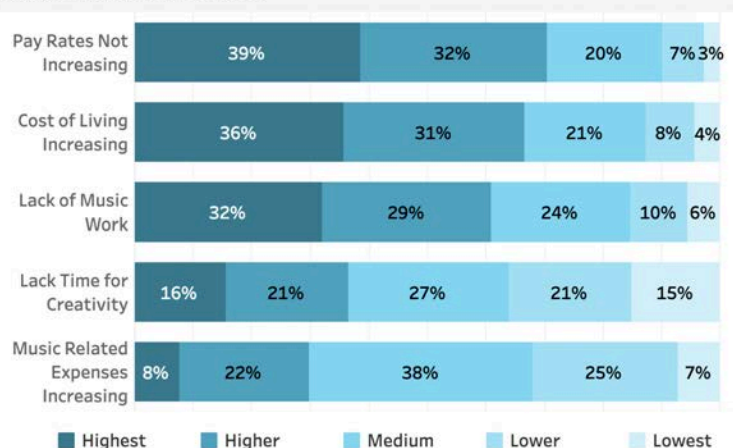
“
Not enough venues. Pay
that has not increased in
many years.
”

Creative: Sources of Income



- Career Concerns** - The main career concerns for Minneapolis Creative respondents include stagnant pay rates, with 39% rating this as the highest concern. Increasing cost of living is a high concern for 36% of Creatives, while 32% are highly concerned about the lack of music work. Time for creativity and increasing music-related expenses are also notable concerns, but to a lesser extent.

Creative Career Concerns

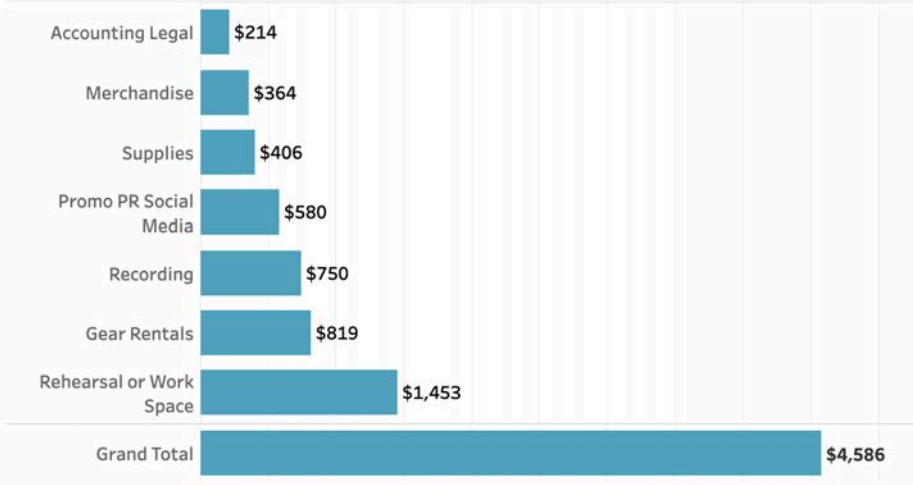


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Creative Profile (continued)

- **Spend** - Creative respondents in Minneapolis spend an average of \$4,589 annually on music-related expenses, highlighting an investment in their careers. The breakdown indicates that the highest costs are for rehearsal or workspace and gear rentals, averaging \$1,453 and \$819 respectively. Recording expenses account for \$750 annually, while promotional activities cost \$580. Supplies and merchandise expenses are \$406 and \$364, respectively, and accounting/legal fees are the lowest at \$214. This spending, especially keeping 60% local, underscores the critical role of Minneapolis Creatives in bolstering the local economy through their financial commitments to various services and products provided by local Industry.

Creative Expenses Annually - Average



\$4,589

Average Creative Spend

\$8M

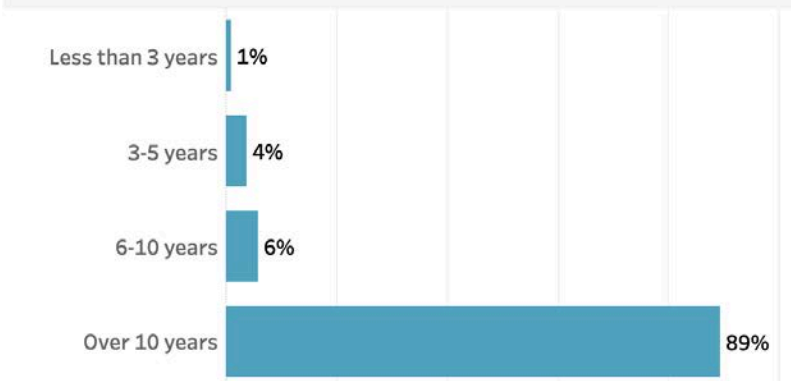
Total Creative Respondents Spend Annually

60%

Spent Locally

- **Experience** - Experience levels among creatives are heavily skewed towards those with over 10 years of experience, who constitute 89% of the population. Those with 6-10 years of experience make up 6%, 3-5 years account for 4%, and less than 3 years represent only 1%. This indicates a well-established professional community with limited new entrants.

Experience - Creatives



“The amount of taxes we pay to be a freelance musician are insane.”

“Finding any paying work is difficult. Opportunities are limited, many places don't pay at all, and those that do rarely pay anything approaching what could be a living wage.”

“Few opportunities for original music bookings.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Venue/Presenter Profile

Minneapolis Venue/Presenter respondents exhibit diverse ownership and operation structures, with 48% being locally owned for-profit entities and 28% nonprofit organizations. Women lead the gender representation at 51%, compared to 42% for men. The venue landscape is varied, with 31% being live music venues, followed by festivals (15%) and independent promoters (13%). Most venues have a capacity of 1-100 (29%), and 71% of venues feature outdoor capabilities. On average, venues host 123 live events annually, contributing to a robust live music scene offering 17,653 total events annually.

Venues average

123

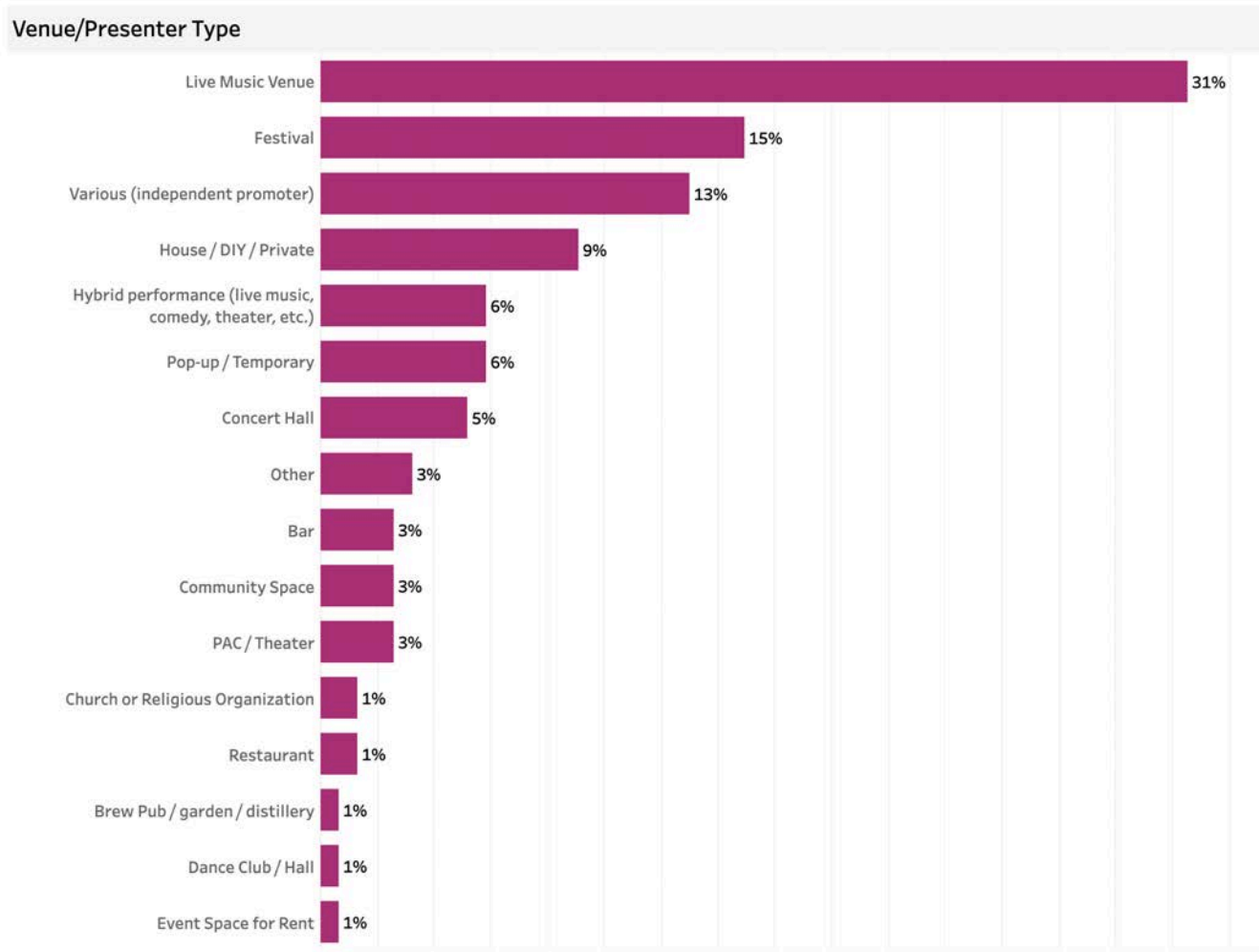
live events/year

17,653

total live events/year

“ Good variety of music venues, mostly inclusive genre-wise ”

“ Inclusivity and cross genre collaboration is my favorite thing about the scene. This strength could also help venues branch into new genres easier, making new spaces for niche genres. ”

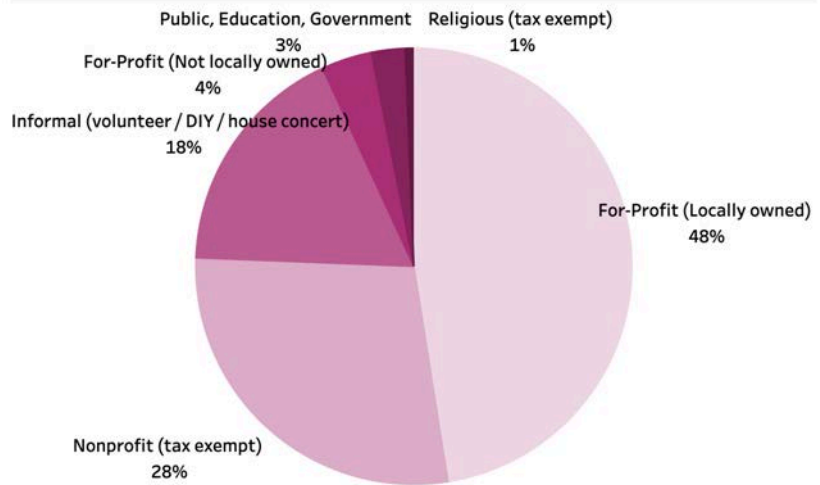


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Venue/Presenter Profile (continued)

- Venue Ownership/Tax Structure** - The ownership structure of respondents is diverse. For-profit (locally owned) entities make up 48% of the ownership, followed by nonprofit (tax-exempt) organizations at 28%. Informal venues, such as volunteer-run, DIY, or house concerts, account for 18%. Other categories include for-profit (not locally owned) at 4%, public/education/government venues at 3%, and religious (tax-exempt) venues at 1%.

Venue/Presenter Ownership (Tax) Structure



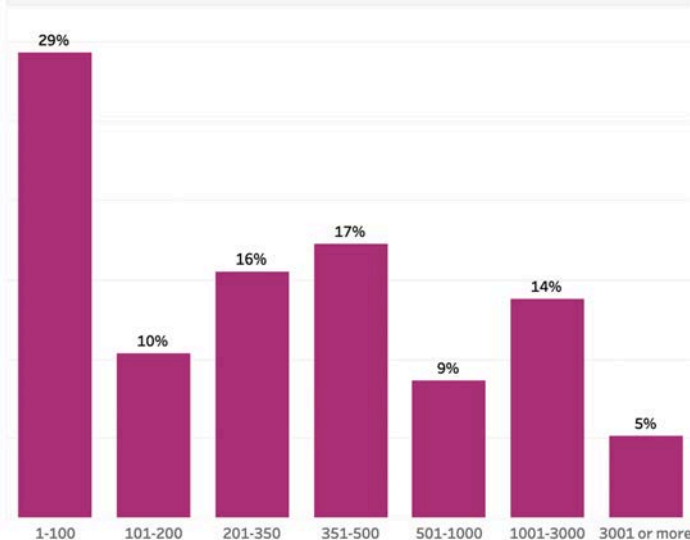
Good mix of venues

It seems fans are not as excited to come out to shows as they used to be.

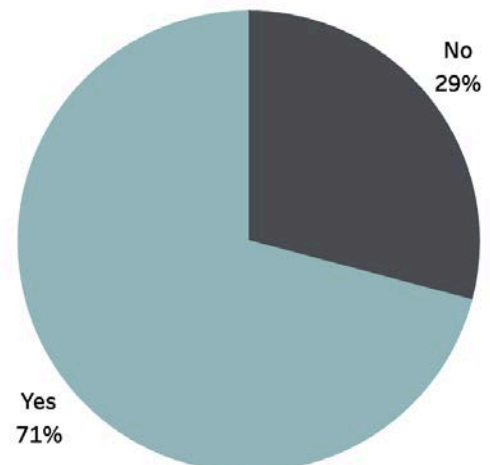
Not enough venues.

- Venue Capacity & Outdoor Capabilities** - In the Minneapolis music ecosystem, Venue capacities range widely, with the largest group having a capacity of 1-100 (29%). Other capacities include 201-350 (16%), 351-500 (17%), 101-200 (10%), 501-1000 (9%), 1001-3000 (14%), and over 3000 (5%). Additionally, 71% of venues have outdoor capabilities, while 29% do not. This indicates a versatile venue landscape with significant outdoor event potential.

Venue Capacity - Owner



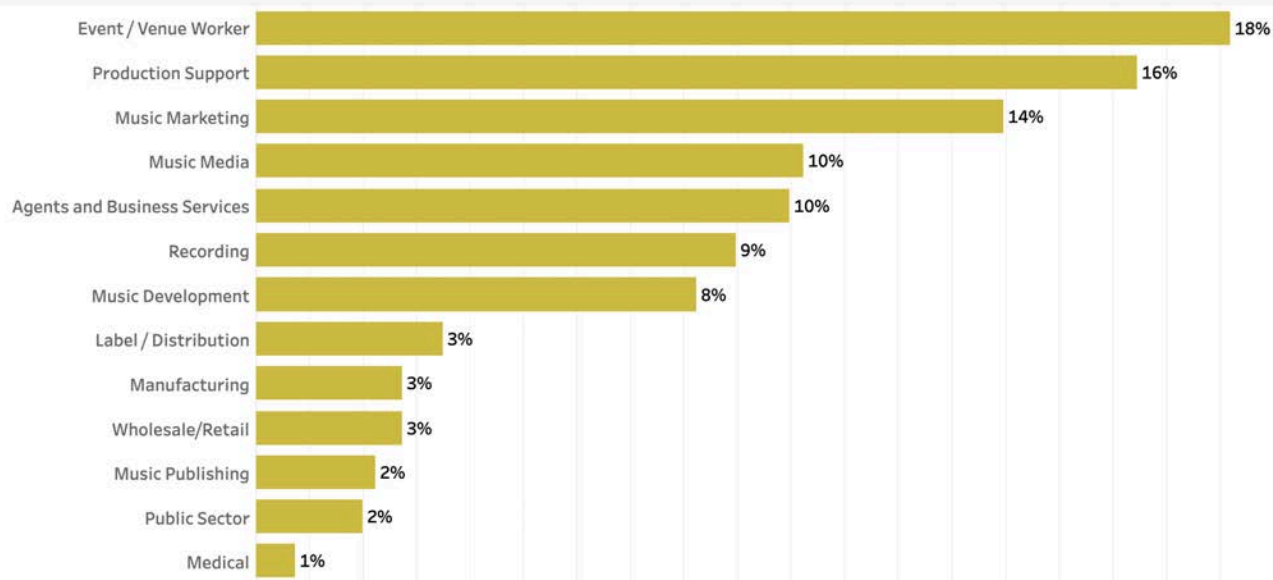
Outdoor Capabilities



Industry Profile

The Minneapolis Music Industry respondents exhibit diverse service access, with many Creatives handling services like booking, publicity, and management themselves. Event/Venue workers are the most common occupation, followed by production support and music marketing. Client bases are broad, with significant local, national, and even some international reach. The industry is male-dominated, with 55% identifying as men and 38% as women, highlighting areas for potential gender diversity improvement.

Industry Current Occupation



- Industry Occupation** - The current occupations of respondents in the music industry are diverse. Event/venue workers make up 18%, followed by production support at 16%, and music marketing at 14%. Music media and agents/business services each account for 10%. Recording professionals make up 9%, and music development 8%. Smaller segments include label/distribution, manufacturing, and wholesale/retail at 3% each, with music publishing and public sector each at 2%, and medical at 1%.

“It's very word-of-mouth, difficult to permeate if you don't already know someone. More networking opportunities could help.”

“How cool would it be if other cities in the U.S. would envy Minneapolis for being the top city for supporting [like REALLY SUPPORTING in all ways] its local music industry?”

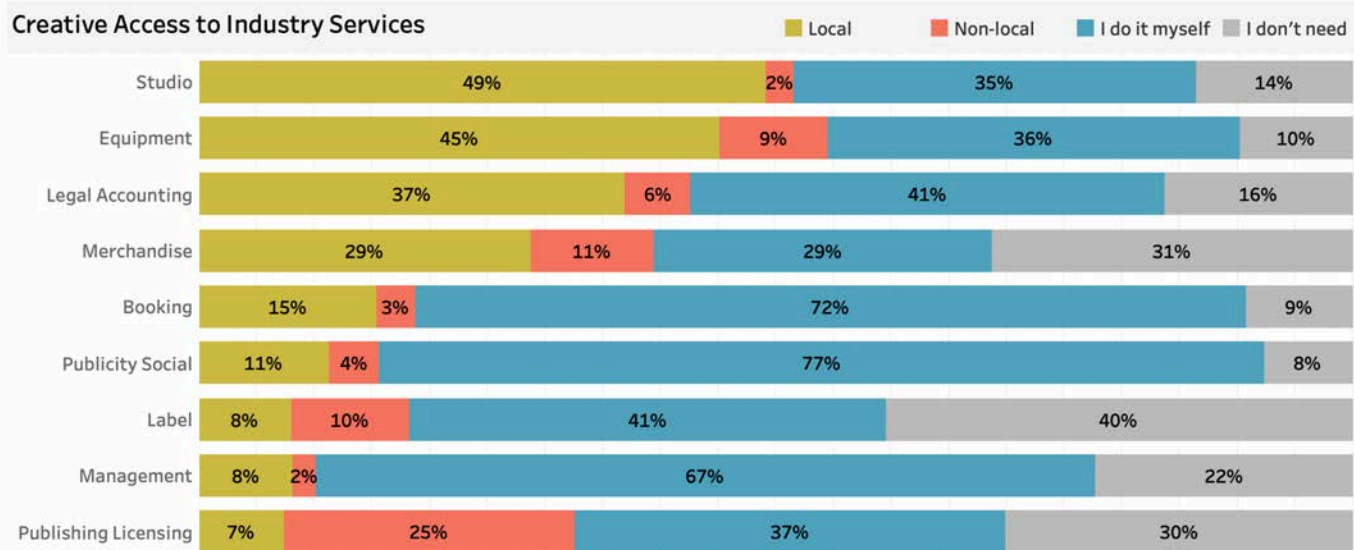
“Administrative and front-of-house workers are not paid adequate and/or competitive wages.”

“It still amazes me that people ask me if this is a full-time job.”

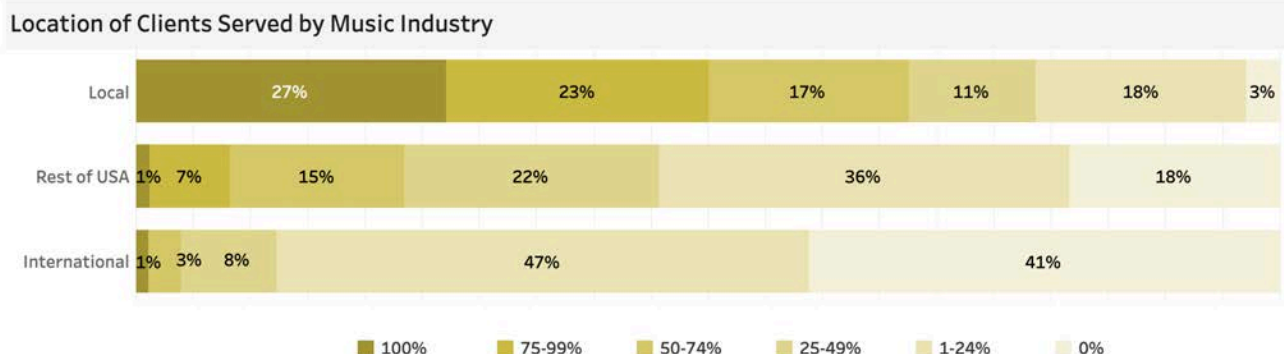
Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Industry Profile (continued)

- **Creative Access to Industry** - Creative respondents access industry services in various ways. For studio and equipment services, around 45-49% use local resources, while 35-36% handle these themselves. Legal/accounting services are managed locally by 37%, with 41% doing it themselves. Merchandise services are split, with 29% local and 31% DIY. Booking, publicity/social, and management services are primarily DIY, with 72-77% handling them themselves. Label and publishing/licensing services see lower local usage (7-8%) with many creatives managing these independently (30-41%).



- **Location of Clients** - Minneapolis Industry is serving primarily local clients. Across the majority of the industry client base, 67% are local, 23% are national, and 12% are international. This highlights a mix of strong local focus and significant national as well as small international engagement.



Getting discovered. Difficult to break into if you are not from the region. A lack of music INDUSTRY (labels, publishing, etc.) at a high level.

Need more accessible and supportive management, licensing, and business services.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity

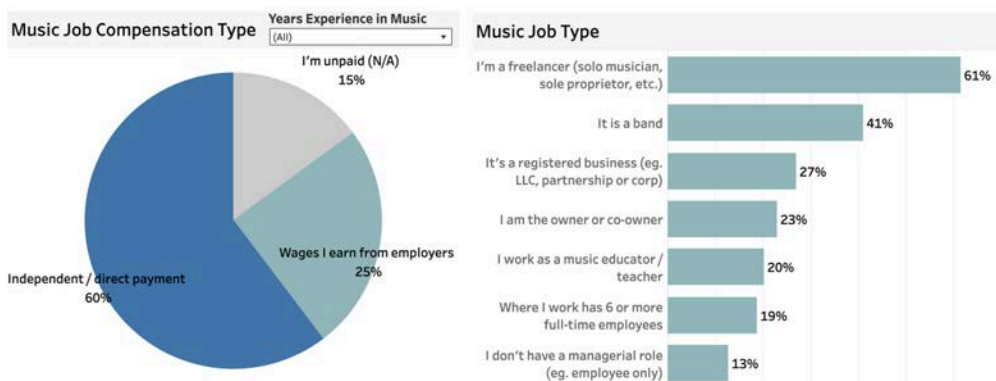
Music generates a total of **\$62M** in income annually across all respondents

29% of respondent annual income comes from music

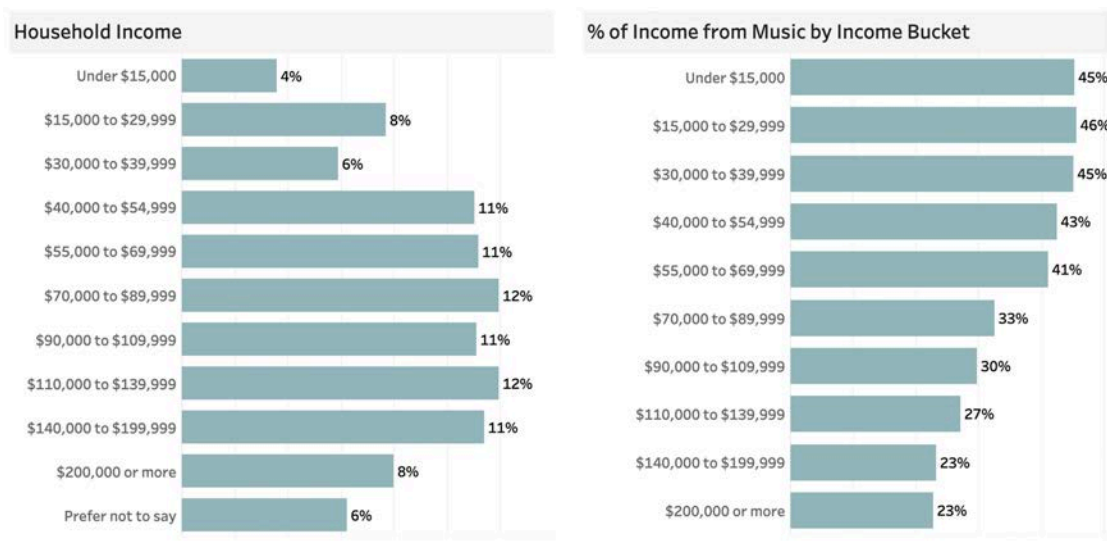
Average household income for respondents is **\$94K**

Average annual income from music is **\$28K/respondent**

Music significantly contributes to the income of Minneapolis music professionals, generating a total of \$62 million annually across all respondents, with 29% of their annual income coming from music and an average annual income from music being \$28,000. The majority of respondents are freelancers (61%) or part of a band (41%), with 60% receiving independent/direct payments. A significant portion, 61%, work outside of music, with 85% of these relying on their outside job as their primary source of income. In publishing and licensing, 50% hold IP rights, with 45% using ASCAP for royalty collection. Local performances are more frequent, with an average pay of \$231 per local gig compared to \$113 for touring. Venues host an average of 123 live events per year, with mixed levels of local talent representation in bookings.



- Music Job Type/Compensation** - The majority of respondents in Minneapolis are freelancers (61%) or part of a band (41%). Independent/direct payment is the primary mode of compensation for 60% of these professionals, while 25% earn wages from employers. Notably, 15% of music workers are unpaid. The diverse job types also include registered businesses, owners/co-owners, music educators, and those working in larger organizations, reflecting a varied and multifaceted local music industry.

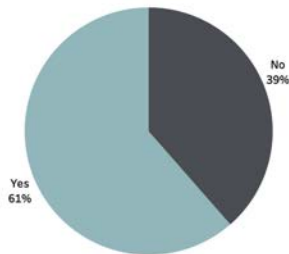


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

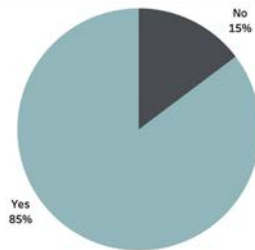
Economic Activity (continued 2/3)

- **Work Outside Music** - A significant portion of music respondents, 61%, reported that they work outside of music to supplement their income. Of those who work outside the music industry, 85% rely on their outside job as their primary source of income. This highlights the financial challenges faced by music professionals, with many needing additional employment to sustain their livelihoods. Only 39% of respondents do not work outside of music, indicating a heavy dependence on supplemental income for the majority.

Work Outside of Music

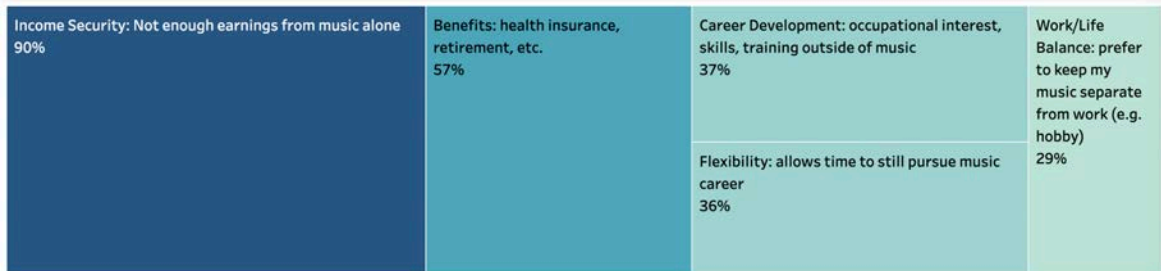


For those who work outside of music, Outside Job Provides Primary Income

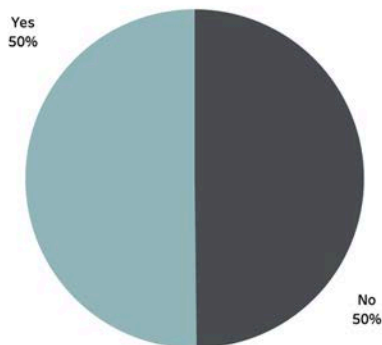


“The cost of housing and workspace has risen at such a dramatic rate that it makes it impossible for most people working in the arts to find affordable space to live and work in.”

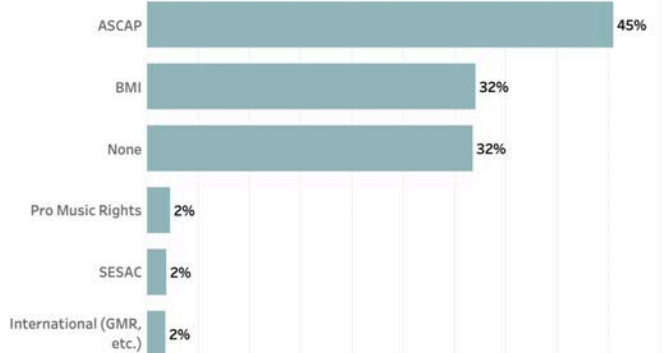
Outside Work Motivation



IP Rightsholder



Royalty Collection Methods



Licensing



- **Publishing/Licensing** - Among music respondents, 50% hold intellectual property (IP) rights. For royalty collection, 45% use ASCAP, while 32% each use BMI and no collection method. Smaller percentages utilize Pro Music Rights, SESAC, or international agencies. When it comes to licensing, 41% do not engage in any licensing activities. Among those who do, 29% rely on a provider (e.g., label services or aggregators), 24% work with publishers or rights admins and 15% have their record label or a sync representative handle licensing.

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Economic Activity (continued 3/3)

- **Creative Performance Frequency & Pay** - Among respondents, 29% perform 1 local paid show per month, while 27% perform 2-3 shows. Only 8% perform 10 or more local shows. For touring, 59% do not perform any paid shows monthly, with 23% performing just one. The average pay per local performance is \$231, whereas touring performances bring in \$113 on average. This data highlights the higher frequency of local performances and the significant disparity in pay between local and touring gigs.

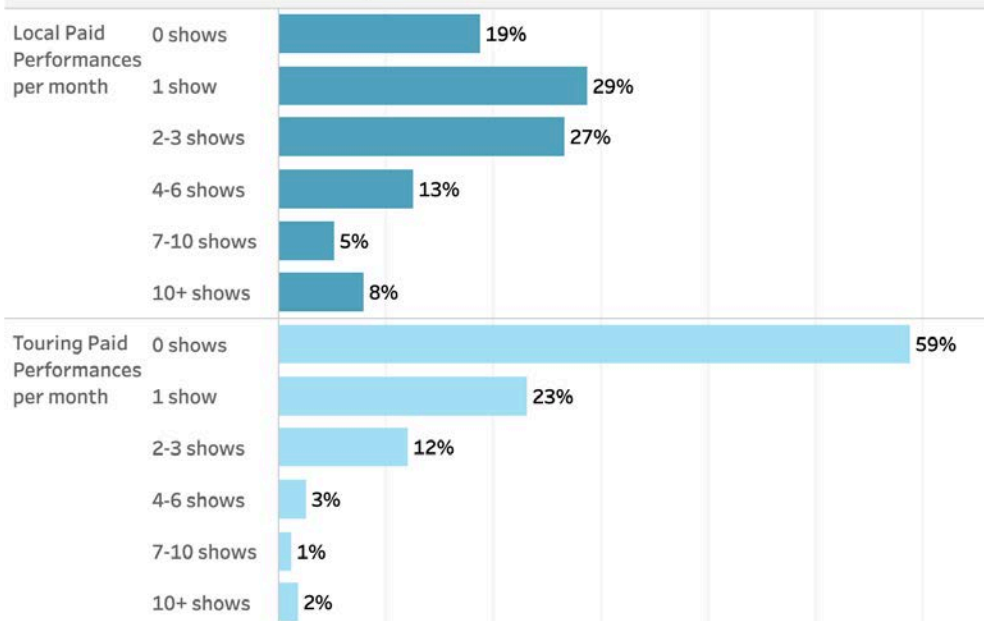
\$231

average pay/local gig

\$113

average pay/touring gig

Creative Paid Performances / Month



“
Loss of venues to play and the need for better pay.
”

“
Pay for musicians needs to be consistent and available.
”

“
The art vs business struggle.
”

“
The pay is comedically low and there's no central location for pro level musicians. In other cities, there are clear places where professional level musicians hang and connect.
”

- **Venue/Presenter** - Venues on average host 123 live events per year, totaling 17,653 events across all respondents. When it comes to booking local talent, 28% of presenters book local headliners for all their events, while 45% do so for supporting acts. However, 22% book very few local headliners, and 19% book very few local supporting acts, highlighting a mixed level of local talent representation in live events.

Venues average

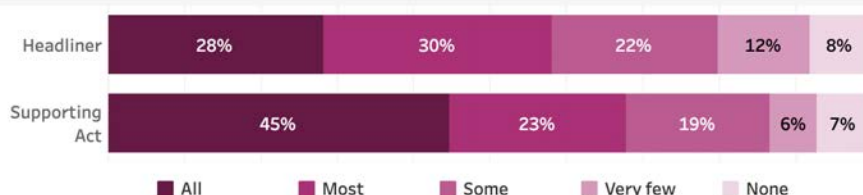
123

live events/year

17,653

total live events/year

Presenters Local Talent Bookings / Month



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development

Commercial workspace status indicates a heavy reliance on rented spaces, with 83% of live performance venues and 77% of temporary live performance spaces rented, making them vulnerable to market trends. Minneapolis ecosystem respondents highlight a preference for connections with music services (51%) and affordable rehearsal spaces (47%). Venues/Presenters prioritize a best practice guide for live music (69%) and audience development tools (67%). Only 24% of respondents have received financial assistance for their music work, facing barriers such as lack of awareness (54%) and grant-writing skills (26%). Financial assistance preferences lean heavily towards financial assistance in the form of funding for tourism and music export (64%) and funding for guaranteed fee for small/medium presentations (58%).

Local Music Resource Preference			
A place to connect with music services (agency, record label, artist management, publicity, business, etc.) 51%	A place to connect and collaborate musically 46%	Studio space and equipment for content creation 36%	Professional Training (music industry specific) 27%
Affordable rehearsal space 47%	A place to connect with other creative industries (film/video, design, tech, gaming, etc.) 45%	Both virtual and in-person community networking 36%	Not needed, or already happening. 15%

Local Music Resource Preferences

- 51% desire a place to connect with music industry services
- 47% want affordable rehearsal space
- 46% seek spaces for musical collaboration
- 45% want to connect with other creative industries like film, design, and tech

“ I feel like the people within the musical ecosystem need to become less siloed and collaborate more. There is definitely elitism and gatekeeping that goes on which prevents everyone from having a seat at the table. ”

“ There is a lack of outdoor music venues, in parks or privately owned/operated. People love being outside, and music is a wonderful addition to being outdoors. Perhaps prioritizing public performance spaces, starting a community partnership management platform could provide opportunities for younger people to get involved and experience in all the areas around live music. ”

“ Our geographic isolation and lack of industry connections has created a scarcity mindset and competitiveness that leads to local gatekeeping. While we have some very inclusive pillars in the community, too many local DJ's and promoters only lift up their friends. ”

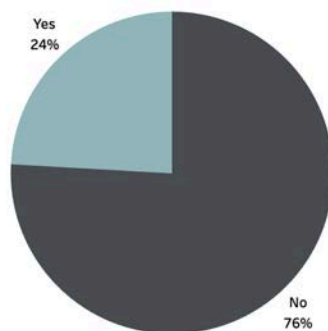
“ It is difficult to inform people about opportunities that will support musicians. My organization ran free and super cheap resources for many years, and many people didn't know about or utilize them. We were always trying to figure out how to reach more people and keep them engaged. ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

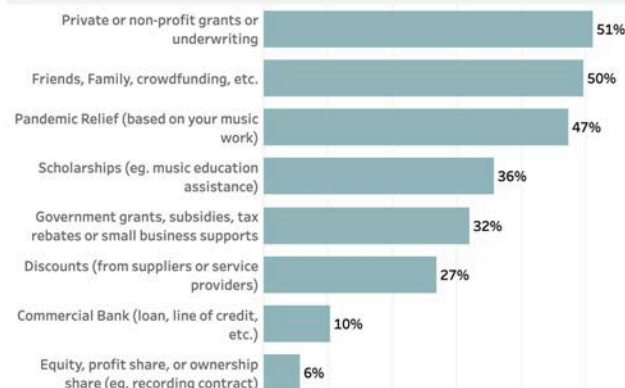
Ecosystem Development (continued 2/3)

- Financial Support -**
 Only 24% of respondents have received financial assistance for their music work, mainly from private or non-profit grants (51%) and support from friends, family, or crowdfunding (50%). Pandemic relief was received by 47%, scholarships by 36%, and government grants by 32%. The main barriers include lack of awareness (54%), grant-writing skills (26%), and time (18%). Respondents show a clear preference for financial assistance in the form of funding for tourism and music export (64%) and funding for guaranteed fee for small/medium presentations (58%). Next is tax breaks (57%) and micro-grants with less oversight are preferred by 51% as well as a data base of grant opportunities for music workers, also at 51%.

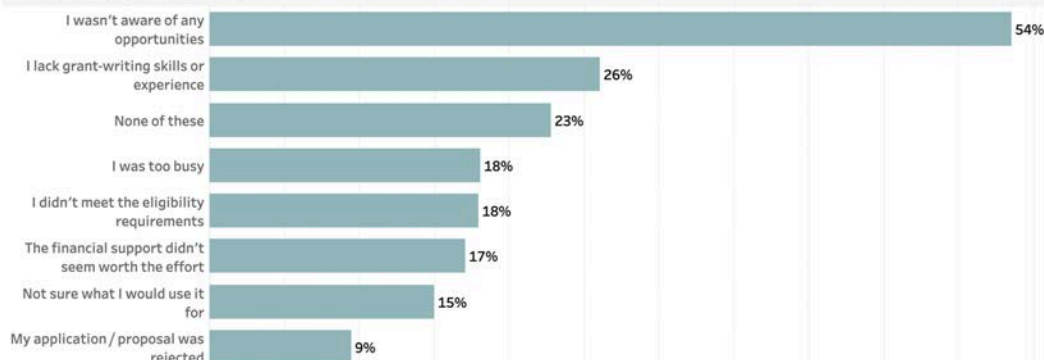
History of Financial Assistance for Music Work



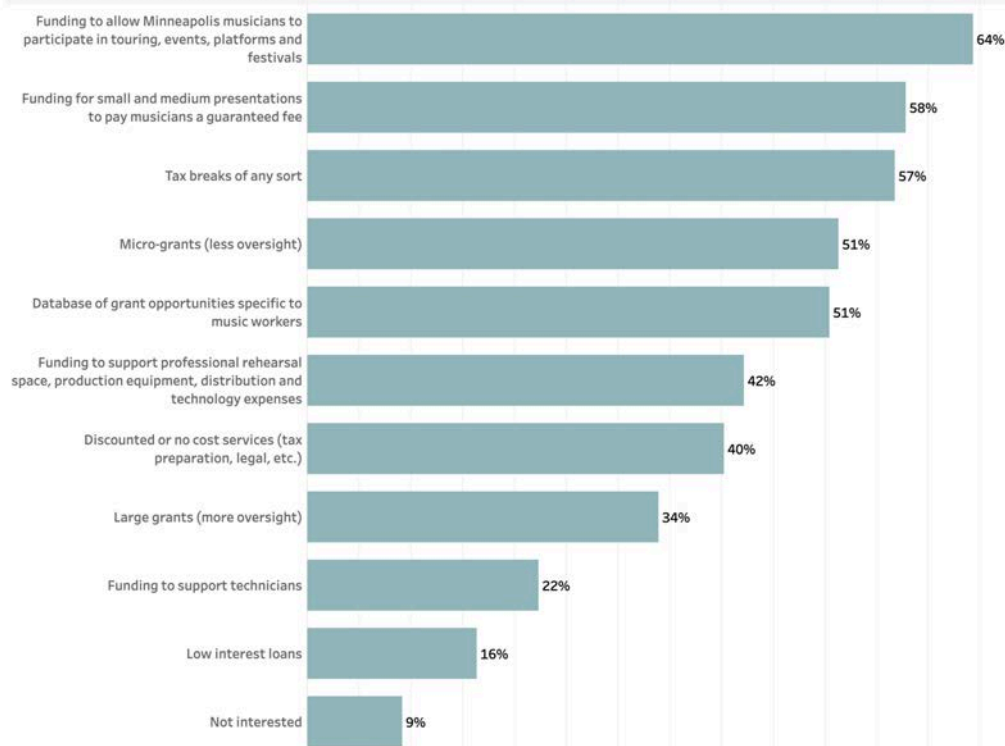
Type of Financial Assistance for Music Work



Financial Assistance Barrier



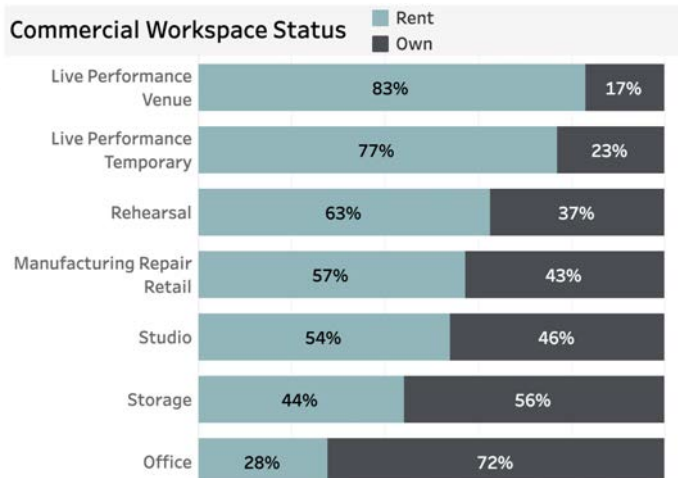
Financial Assistance Preference



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Ecosystem Development (continued 3/3)

- **Commercial Workspace Status** - The majority of respondents rent their commercial workspaces, with 83% renting live performance venues and 77% renting temporary live performance spaces. This high dependency on rental spaces makes these venue types particularly susceptible to market trends and economic fluctuations. Additionally, 63% rent rehearsal spaces, and 57% rent manufacturing, repair, and retail spaces. The reliance on rented spaces extends to studios (54%) and storage spaces (44%). This reliance on rental properties can pose financial risks, making it difficult to secure long-term stability.



Venue/Presenters Preference for Business Resources



- **Venue/Presenter Business Resources** - The data on Venue/Presenter business preferences show that 69% prioritize having a best practice guide for presenting live music locally. Audience development tools and venue/presenter coalitions follow closely, with 67% and 62%, respectively. A current directory of local production providers is important to 53% of respondents, and 48% seek tax-status blind public arts funding. Industry-specific workforce development and formal access to local planning or advocacy are also significant, with 47% and 46% respectively.

“ I believe there are a lack of opportunities and safe places for Native Americans to thrive and feel welcome in music. There are a lack of places for social connections. Many music schools don't have rock music or popular music. They are stuck in the classical and militaristic world of orchestra and concert band. I wish education and musicians could better tap into the youth scene for rock music. ”

“ We need fewer individual events and programs, and we need more people working together. We have the country's biggest ad agencies and biggest foundations in the same town that gave birth to Prince, Dylan, Replacements, Lizzo, etc., and yet we have NO cohesive brand or support system for the music scene like Austin, Fort Collins, Nashville, Tulsa. Everyone wants their own block party rather than a summer-long approach to driving tourism as well as filling the need of locals. We can't sustain it. Artists can't make a living that way; we are cannibalizing our own audiences, and the same bands keep playing over and over again, just in slightly altered lineups. ”

“ The lack of affordable (or just any) rehearsal and teaching space is very surprising considering how vibrant our arts scene is. ”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Workforce Development

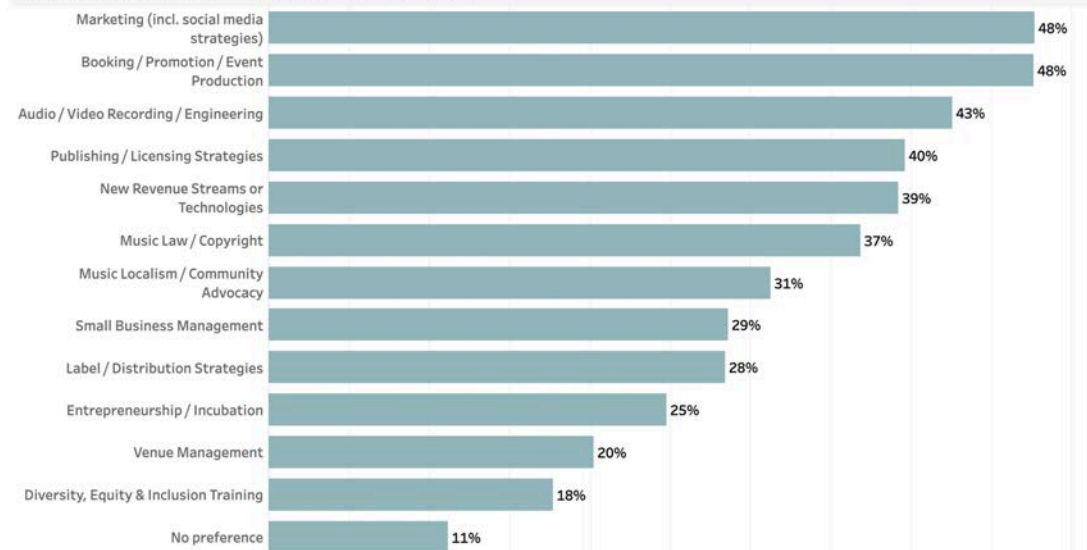
Despite 84% of Minneapolis respondents having extensive experience (over 10 years) in the music industry, 53% do not hold any memberships or registrations with professional organizations. Those who do are mainly affiliated with royalty collection and music licensing organizations (28%). For professional development, respondents prefer continuing education or specialized training (47%) and leadership training (42%), while 32% favor introductory training.

- Professional Development -** Minneapolis respondents show a strong interest in professional development training, particularly in marketing, including social media strategies, and booking/promotion/event production, with each skill preferred by 48% of respondents. Additionally, 43% are interested in audio/video recording and engineering training. Other significant areas of interest include publishing/licensing strategies (40%), new revenue streams or technologies (39%), and music law/copyright (37%).

Professional Development Training Level Preference

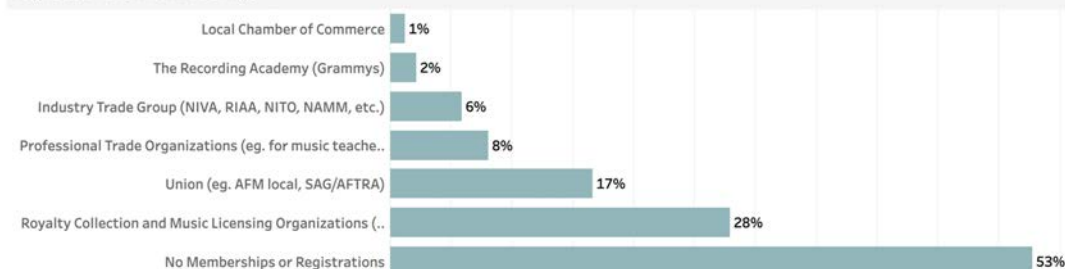


Professional Development Training Skill Preference



- Professional Industry Associations -** A significant portion of respondents (53%) do not hold any memberships or registrations. Of those who do, 28% are members of royalty collection and music licensing organizations. Unions and professional trade organizations are also notable, with 17% and 8% respectively. Smaller percentages are affiliated with industry trade groups (6%), the Recording Academy (2%), and local chambers of commerce (1%).

Registrations Memberships

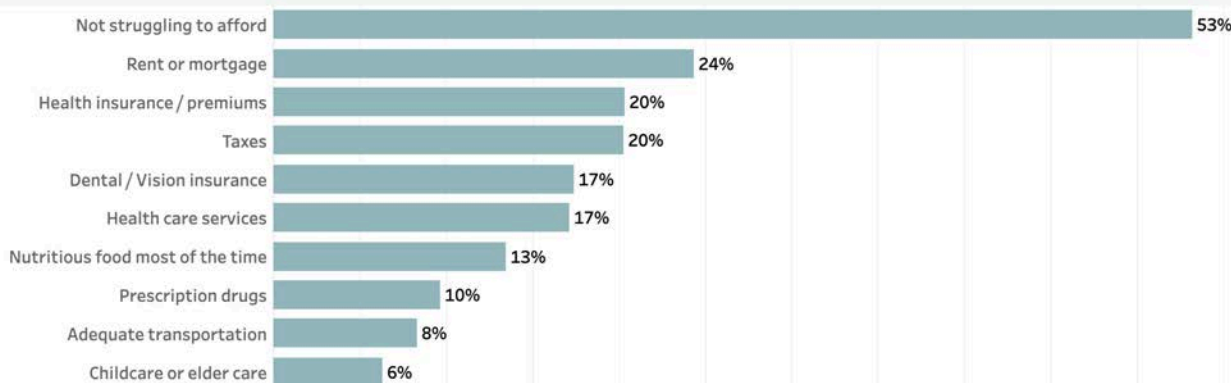


Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Livability

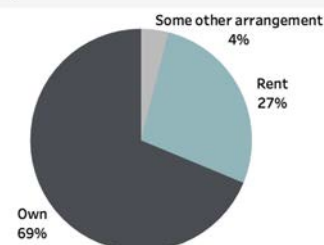
While 53% of respondents do not struggle with affordability, 24% face rent or mortgage challenges, and 20% grapple with both health insurance and taxes. Creative career concerns highlight issues like pay rates not increasing (39%) and the rising cost of living (36%). Music career challenges are topped by low or uncertain pay (89%) and lack of benefits (71%). Venue and presenter challenges emphasize talent costs as the highest concern, with 27% ranking it as the top issue. A majority of respondents (69%) own their homes, one of the highest home ownership percentages seen across the Music Census.

Affordability Struggles



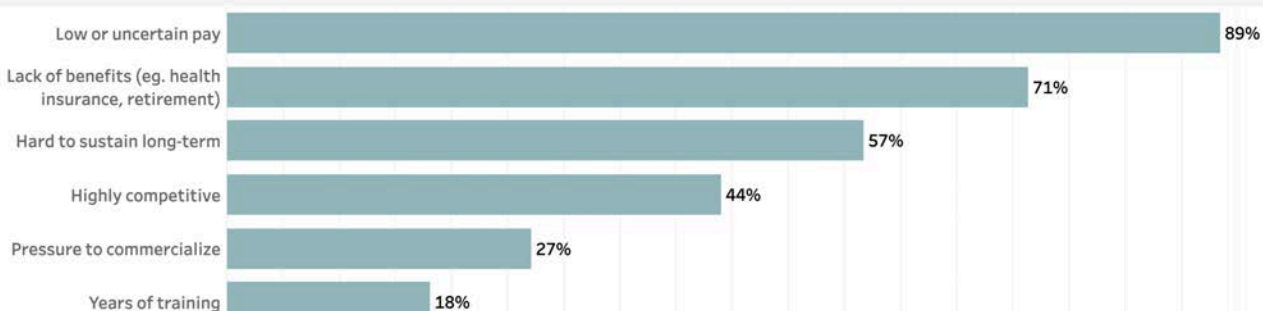
- **Affordability** - Survey respondents indicate that 53% do not struggle with affordability. However, 24% face challenges affording rent or mortgage, and 20% each struggle with health insurance premiums and taxes. Additionally, 17% have difficulties affording dental and vision insurance and healthcare services. Nutritious food is a concern for 13%, prescription drugs for 10%, adequate transportation for 8%, and childcare or elder care for 6%.

Current Housing



- **Music Career Challenges** - Survey respondents highlight several significant music career challenges, with 89% citing low or uncertain pay as a primary issue. Lack of benefits, such as health insurance and retirement plans, is a concern for 71% of respondents. Additionally, 57% find it hard to sustain a music career long-term, and 44% note the highly competitive nature of the industry.

Music Career Challenges



“Affordable housing is a huge issue. Artists and musicians are getting pushed out because they can't afford to live here anymore.”

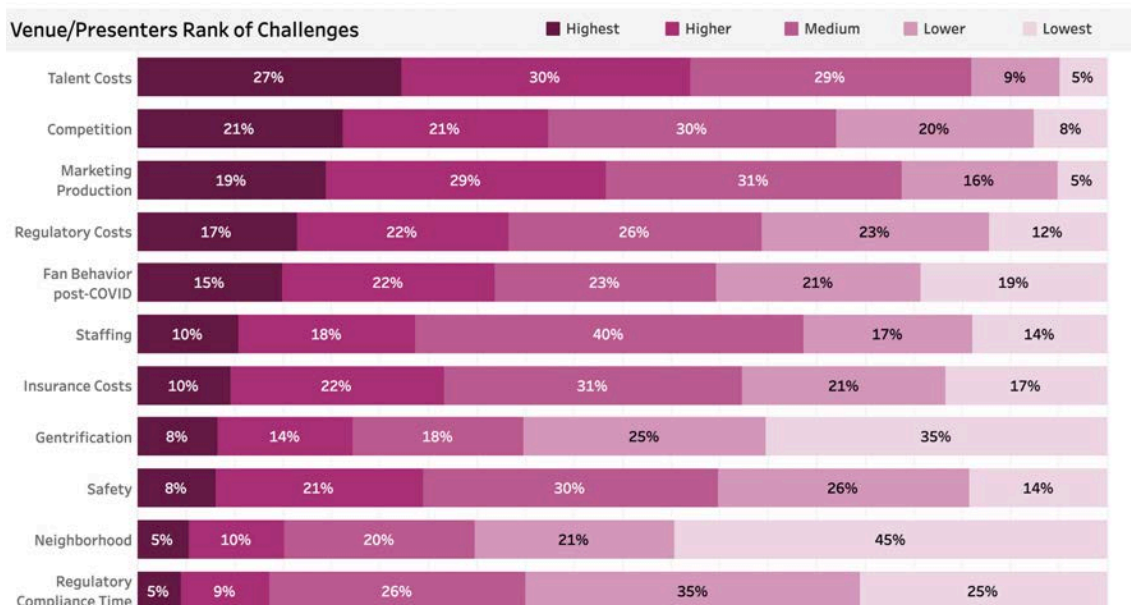
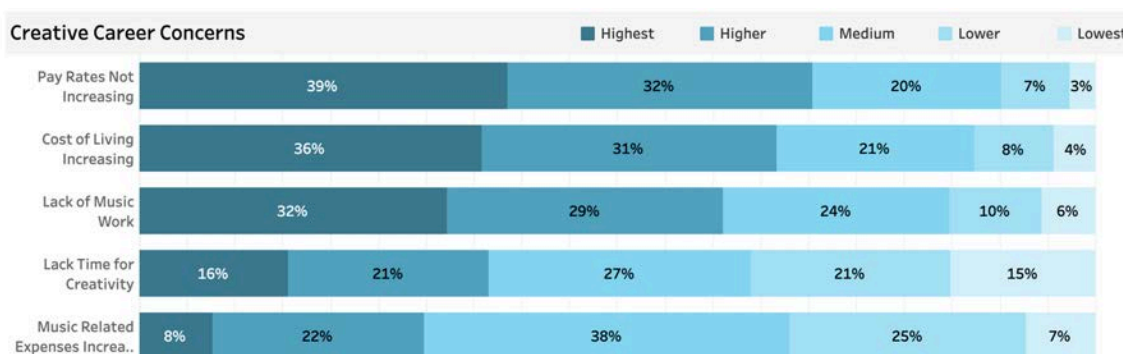
“Affordability is a major concern. We need more initiatives to support affordable living and working conditions for musicians.”

“The cost of living is getting higher and higher, but gig pay remains the same. It's becoming impossible to sustain a career in music here.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Livability (continued)

- **Creative Career Concerns** - The top issues include pay rates not increasing, cited by 39% as the highest concern and 32% as a higher concern, and the increasing cost of living, with 36% marking it as the highest and 31% as a higher concern. Additionally, 32% of respondents are highly concerned about the lack of music work, while 29% view it as a higher concern. Other significant issues include the lack of time for creativity (16% highest, 21% higher) and increasing music-related expenses (8% highest, 22% higher).
- **Venue/Presenters Rank of Challenges** - Venue and presenter respondents identify talent costs as their highest challenge, with 27% ranking it as the top concern and 30% as a higher concern. Competition and marketing/production costs are also significant issues, with 21% and 19% respectively marking them as the highest challenges. Regulatory costs, fan behavior post-COVID, and insurance costs are other notable concerns. Staffing issues, gentrification, safety, and neighborhood factors also pose medium to lower challenges.



“The rising cost of living and rents going up make it hard for musicians to stay and thrive in this city. We need affordable spaces to live and work.”

“It's becoming increasingly difficult to find affordable rehearsal spaces. Many musicians are struggling to keep up with the rising costs.”

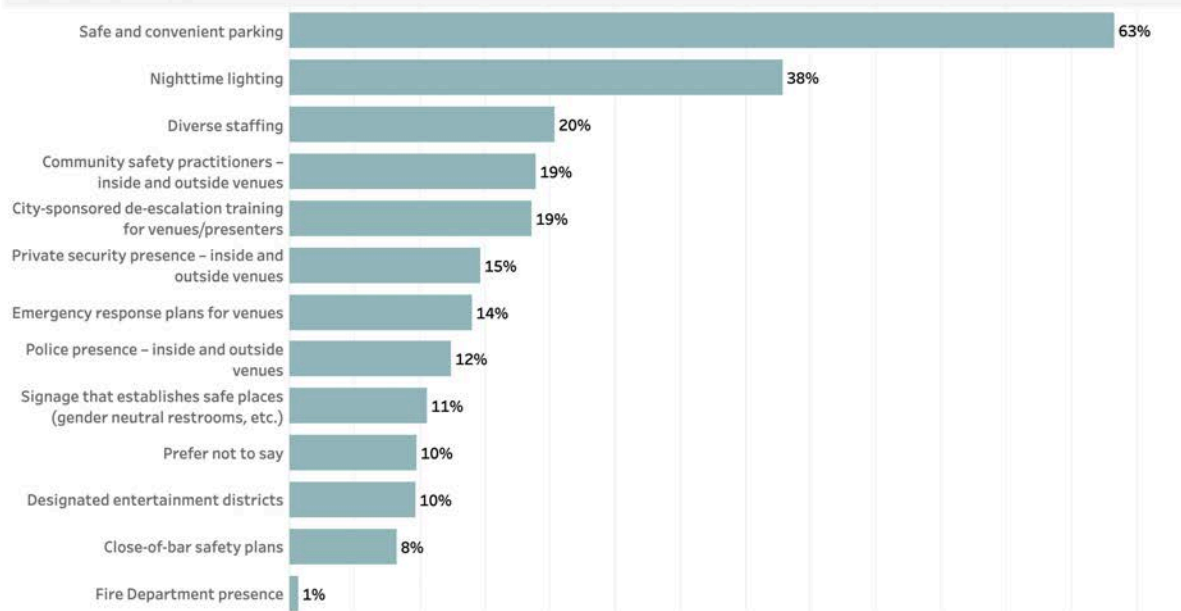
“Affordable housing and rehearsal spaces are critical. Without them, the local music scene will continue to suffer.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies

Venues/Presenters face significant regulatory challenges, with sound policy, cost of permits, and confusion/inefficiency being the most pressing issues. The most common regulatory processes encountered by venues and presenters include security and public safety (71%), street and parking regulations (69%), and amplified sound regulations (60%). Financial assistance preferences lean heavily towards financial assistance in the form of funding for tourism and music export (64%) and funding for guaranteed fee for small/medium presentations (58%). Venues/Presenters also favor regulatory tools such as tax discounts, waivers (84%), and having an advocate inside government (77%). Safety concerns for music ecosystem respondents emphasize the need for safe parking (63%) and nighttime lighting (38%). Lastly, the Minneapolis 3% Entertainment Tax is generally seen as neutral by 83% of respondents, though 8% find it somewhat negative, and 5% view it very negatively.

When it comes to personal/public safety, what would most address safety issues impacting your music work? Select a maximum of three.



- **Addressing Safety Concerns for Music Workers** - When it comes to addressing personal and public safety issues impacting their music work, respondents highlighted the need for safe and convenient parking (63%) and nighttime lighting (38%) as top priorities. Other significant measures include diverse staffing (20%), community safety practitioners both inside and outside venues (19%), and city-sponsored de-escalation training for venues/presenters (19%). Private security presence (15%), emergency response plans (14%), and police presence (12%) were also noted, along with signage for safe places (11%) and designated entertainment districts (10%).
- **Entertainment Tax Impact** - The Minneapolis 3% Entertainment Tax has a predominantly neutral impact on music-related work, with 83% of respondents indicating neutrality. However, 8% feel the tax somewhat negatively affects their work, and 5% view it very negatively, seeing it as a barrier. Conversely, 3% find it somewhat positive, and 1% feel it very positively supports their music work.

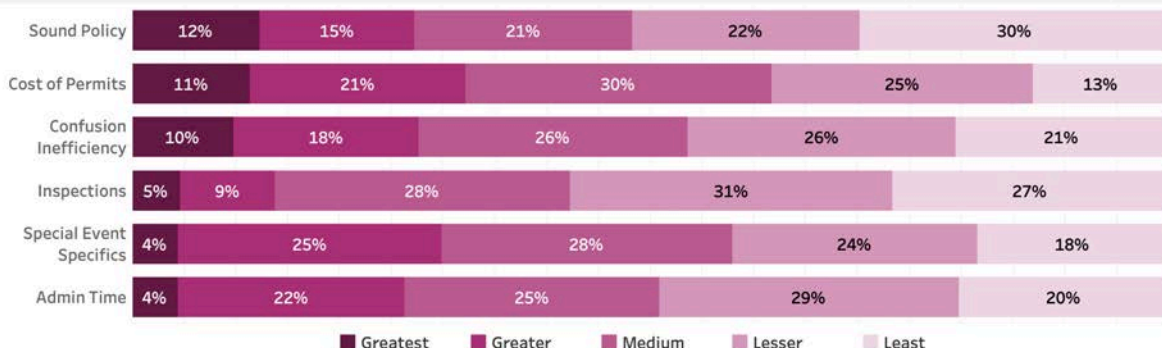
How does the Minneapolis 3% Entertainment Tax impact your music-related work?



Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

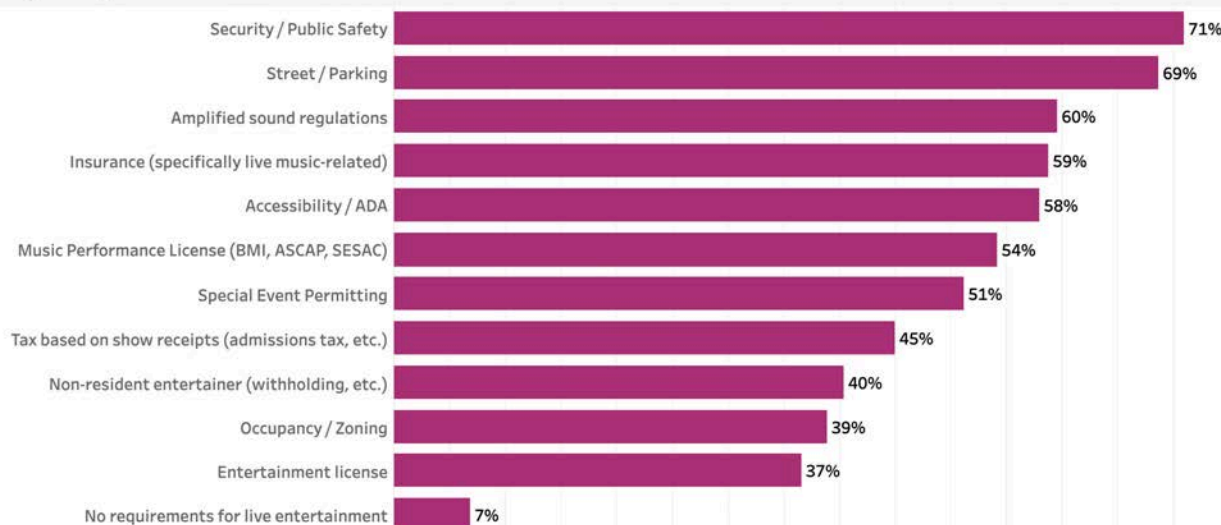
Music-Friendly Policies (continued 2/3)

Presenters Rank of Regulatory Challenges



- Regulatory Challenges** - Venue/Presenters face several regulatory challenges, with sound policy, cost of permits, and confusion/inefficiency topping the list. Sound policy is considered the greatest challenge by 12% of respondents although 48% rank it high. While 11% rank cost of permits as their top challenge, 62% mark it as a medium-greatest challenge, and similarly 54% feel impacted by confusion/inefficiency with 10% marking it as their top challenge. While only 5% mark it as their top challenge, 42% find inspections a concern, while special event specifics and administrative time each present challenges for 57% and 51% of respondents, respectively.
- Regulatory Fluency** - Venue and presenters encounter various regulatory processes when hosting live entertainment. The most common are security and public safety requirements (71%), street and parking regulations (69%), and amplified sound regulations (60%). Insurance specific to live music impacts 59%, accessibility/ADA compliance 58%, and music performance licenses (BMI, ASCAP, SESAC) 54%. Special event permitting affects 51%, and taxes based on show receipts impact 45%. Additional challenges include non-resident entertainer withholding (40%), occupancy/zoning laws (39%), and entertainment licenses (37%). Only 7% of respondents report no regulatory requirements.

Regulatory Processes Encountered to Present Live Entertainment



“The city’s noise ordinances are too strict and make it difficult for venues to host live music without constant complaints and fines.”

“Navigating the city’s permitting process is a nightmare. It’s overly complex and discourages new venues from opening or existing ones from expanding their services.”

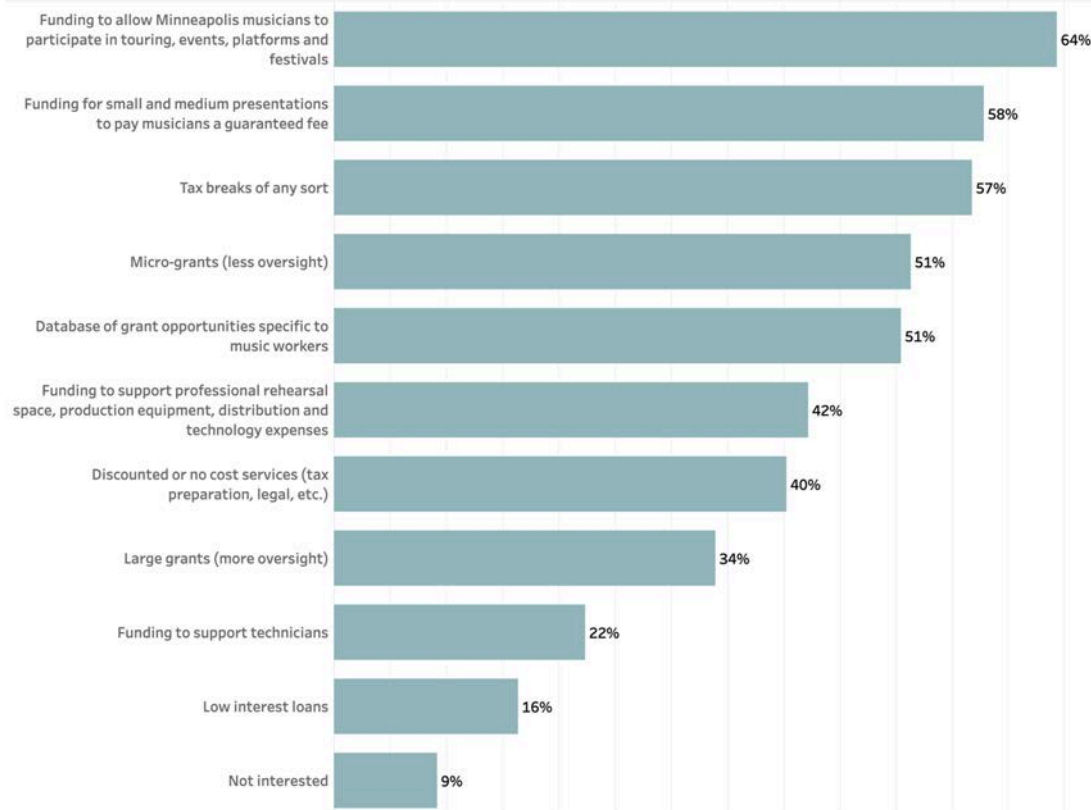
“The city needs to streamline its regulations. Right now, it feels like they are making it harder for musicians and venues to thrive rather than supporting them.”

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Music-Friendly Policies (continued 3/3)

- Financial Assistance Preferences** - Respondents show a clear preference for financial assistance in the form of funding for tourism and music export (64%) and funding for guaranteed fee for small/medium presentations (58%). Next is tax breaks (57%) and micro-grants with less oversight are preferred by 51% as well as a data base of grant opportunities for music workers, also at 51%.

Financial Assistance Preference



- Venue/Presenter Tool Preference** - Presenters express a strong preference for regulatory tools that support the hosting of live music, with 84% favoring tax discounts, waivers, and incentives. An advocate inside the government is desired by 77%, while 74% prefer having a single point of contact for permitting and a web page with current regulations. Online portals for permitting and communication are preferred by 73%, and tiered compliance fees based on the scale or type of presentation by 58%. Annual training sessions and updates from the regulatory body are favored by 49%.

Why doesn't the city allocate a budget to pay musicians for performances in public parks? It would be a great way to support local artists and bring more live music to the community.

We need the city to prioritize noise policy reforms that are more supportive of live music venues. Current regulations are too restrictive and make it difficult for venues to operate.

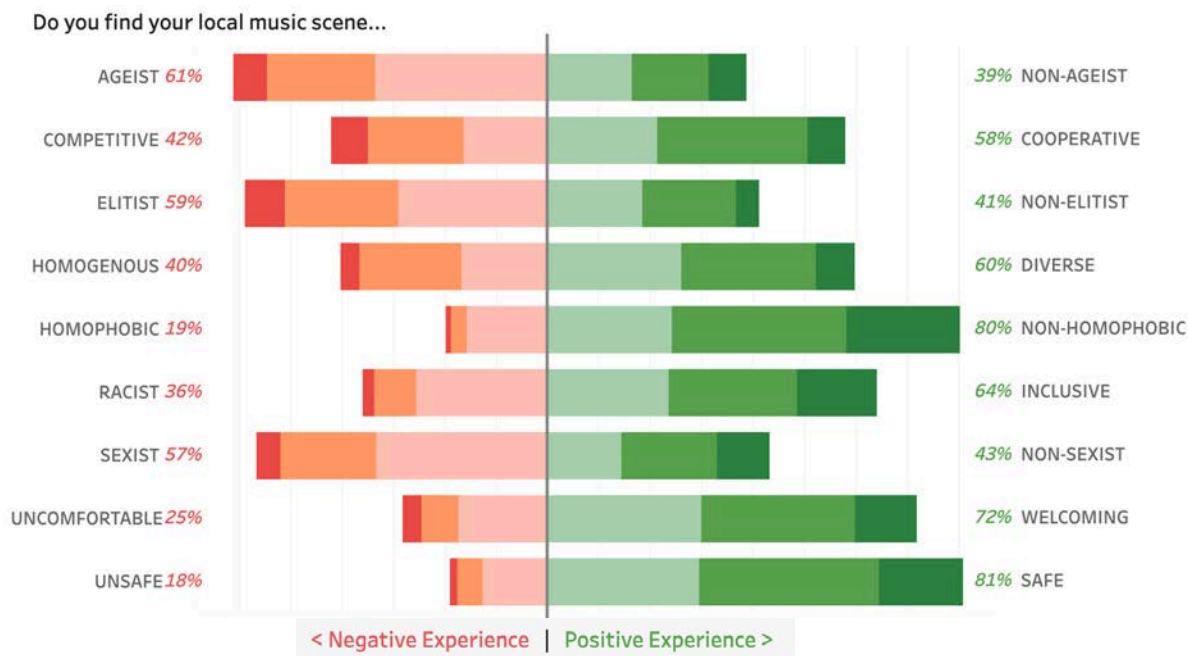
Presenters Regulatory Tools Preference

Tax discounts, waivers, incentives to host live music 84%	One point of contact for permitting (vs. separate departments) 74%	Online portal for permitting and communication 73%	Annual training sessions and updates from regulatory body 49%
An advocate inside government (eg. Office of Nightlife, Creative or Music) 77%	Webpage of current regulations (specifically for live music) 74%	Tiered compliance, fees based on scale or type of presentation 58%	

Music Ecosystem Health Assessment

Culture & Belonging

The Minneapolis music ecosystem offers many positive experiences, but has a few challenges. The Minneapolis music ecosystem challenges are ageism, elitism, and sexism. The Minneapolis music ecosystem's greatest strengths are that it is safe, non-homophobic, and welcoming.



Subgroup Insights

Please see the online dashboard at [Minneapolis Arts & Cultural Affairs](#) for full data on each indicator by subgroup. Some overarching themes to the subgroups are:

- **Negative experiences** - While respondent representation was lower than the general population from those who identify as Black, African, or African American, they experience the most negative (red) side of the Minneapolis ecosystem. Additionally, people who identify as Gay or Lesbian, Asexual, and Bisexual tend to experience negative (red) side of the Minneapolis music ecosystem more than others.

“ I love that there is so much diversity in styles and people involved in the music scene here. ”

“ More efforts should be made to include underrepresented groups in the local music industry. ”

“ The fact that it's still very male-dominated in the industry, referrals and true mentorship are hard to find. ”

“ How can we improve diversity and inclusion in our music scene? ”

“ It would be beneficial to have more discussions and actions focused on diversity and inclusion. ”

“ Sexist industry full of straight white men. ”

“ The inclusive nature of the community. Everyone is welcome and supported. ”

“ There's a growing awareness about the importance of diversity and representation in our music community. ”

“ There is woman tax for being a musician, a mother tax for being a musician, a BIPOC tax for being a musician and a wealth tax for being a musician. ”

Key Insights

Economic Contributions: Music significantly contributes to the income of Minneapolis music professionals, generating a total of \$62 million annually across all respondents. Creative annual expenses yields a collective spend of over \$8M annually of which 60% stays local. However, many professionals face financial challenges, with 61% working outside of music and 85% of these relying on their outside job as their primary source of income.

Music Ecosystem Composition: The Minneapolis music ecosystem is predominantly composed of individuals in the Music Creative sector (75%), with smaller representations in Industry (17%) and Venue/Presenter roles (8%). The demographic composition is predominantly White/European Origin (84%), with underrepresentation of Black, African, or African American (3%) and Asian or Asian American (2%) populations compared to the Minneapolis general population.

Experience Levels: A significant majority (84%) of the music ecosystem participants have over 10 years of experience, indicating a mature workforce. This suggests stability but also highlights a need to attract and nurture new talent to sustain growth and innovation, especially the 18–24-year-old segment of the community.

Performance Opportunities: Local live performances are a primary income source, relied on significantly by 49% of creatives. Despite the frequency of local performances, there is a notable disparity in pay between local gigs (\$231 per performance) and touring gigs (\$113 per performance).

Professional Development: There is a strong demand for professional development, particularly in areas like marketing, booking, and audio/video recording.

Venue/Presenter Challenges: Venue/Presenters face significant regulatory challenges, with sound policy, permit costs, and administrative inefficiency being the most pressing issues. Many venues are particularly vulnerable to economic fluctuations, with 83% renting their spaces.

Financial Assistance: Only 24% of respondents have received financial assistance for their music work, with main barriers including lack of awareness (54%) and grant-writing skills (26%). Preferred types of assistance include financial assistance in the form of funding for tourism and music export (64%) and funding for guaranteed fee for small/medium presentations (58%).

Public Safety Concerns: Safety for music workers is a priority, with top concerns including safe parking (63%) and nighttime lighting (38%).

Inclusivity and Diversity: The need for greater inclusivity and diversity within the Minneapolis music scene is evident, with calls for more representation of women, queer individuals, and people of color, especially Black, African, and African American.



Photos Courtesy of Minneapolis Arts and Cultural Affairs

Opportunities

Regulatory Challenges: Create a live music task force comprised of City staff, Venue/Presenter owners, and Musicians to delve deeper into regulatory issues, enabling the City to partner more effectively in solving regulatory challenges. This task force could work towards streamlining processes, reducing permit costs, and addressing sound policy concerns to support a thriving live music scene, while also establishing better communication and relationships.

Economic Contributions: Develop initiatives that leverage the significant economic contributions of the music industry, such as offering financial incentives or grants to sustain and grow local music careers, especially music export programs and guaranteed pay for small/medium presentations.

Inclusivity and Diversity: Implement programs to increase diversity and foster a more inclusive music scene by supporting initiatives that promote the participation of women, queer individuals, and people of color in the music industry, especially Black, African, and African American, and Asian populations.

Experience Levels: Attract and nurture young (18-24 year olds) talent through mentorship programs, apprenticeships, and targeted support for emerging musicians.

Professional Development: Increase access to professional development resources, offering training in key areas like marketing, booking, and audio/video recording to help musicians and industry professionals thrive.

Venue/Presenter Barriers: Provide financial support and incentives for venue assistance and resilience, particularly for those renting spaces and vulnerable to market trends.

Financial Assistance: Raise awareness of available financial assistance programs and simplify the application process to increase accessibility. Focus on offering funding for tourism, pay guarantees, tax breaks, and micro-grants to alleviate economic pressures.

Safety Concerns: Implement city-wide initiatives to improve safety for music workers, such as better lighting, secure parking, and safety training programs.



Photos Courtesy of Minneapolis Arts and Cultural Affairs